MUSIC ▼

Back to the Roots

US-based Hindustani classical vocalist **Mahesh Kale** is on a concert tour through India

After captivating audiences across Europe, the United States and Canada with his deeply evocative devotional performances, Mahesh Kale—one of India's leading Hindustani classical vocalists—has returned to India with 'Abhangwari' (songs in praise of Lord Vithoba). The highly anticipated concert tour began on June 29 in Indore and continues through July with performances in Mumbai, Pune, Delhi, Chennai, Bengaluru, Nagpur and Kolkata.

For Kale, Abhangwari is not simply a concert tour, it is a deeply personal and spiritual endeavour. "Abhangwari, in particular, and Indian classical music, in general, is like soul food. No matter how many times you experience it, the craving never fades; if anything, it intensifies," he says. While the performances follow a familiar structure, each concert brings its own energy. "Each pilgrimage may follow a similar path, but the journey feels different every time because of the fellow travellers—our audience." This connection with listeners, he notes, gives each performance its unique emotional texture.

Now based in the San Francisco Bay Area, Kale holds master's degrees in engineering and management. He once had a successful career in Silicon Valley, which he chose to leave behind to follow his passion for Indian classical music. "Letting go of my engineering career allowed me to focus on cultural preservation through music," he explains.

His versatility—shaped by years of training under Pandit Jitendra Abhisheki—has made him a torchbearer of both classical and devotional music. Abhangwari continues to evolve with new compositions and arrangements. "The audience can expect a blend of the familiar and the fresh. It's a tradition that renews itself constantly."

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Kale's collaborations with global musicians and his efforts through the Mahesh Kale School of Music, now serving students in over 15 countries, reflect his commitment to making Indian music accessible. "Even if one doesn't sing perfectly, the act itself brings joy," he says. "All of them [his students] carry the music forward in one way or another." ■

—Nikhil Sardana

Upcoming performances: Bharat Mandapam, Delhi (July 11); Narada Gana Sabha Auditorium, Chennai (July 12); Chowdiah Memorial Hall, Bengaluru (July 13); Kavivarya Suresh Bhat Auditorium, Nagpur (July 19); GD Birla Sabhaghar, Kolkata (July 20)

